ernment functioning on ventilator support from an ideologically dogmatic Left wasn't expected to last a year, much less complete a decade in power.

If the UPA did provide a measure of stability amidst the pulls and pressures of coalition politics, credit must go to Dr Singh's non-combative persona and, more crucially, Sonia Gandhi's willingness to place collective pragmatism above personal ambition. For years, she had been hounded by the 'foreign origins' tag, and yet when it came to the crunch, she was willing to align with some of the very forces who had repeatedly questioned her leadership credentials. The Sonia Gandhi-Manmohan Singh *jugalbandi* was based on mutual respect and a distinct division of roles: 10 Janpath was the undisputed political power centre, Dr Singh was the faithful bureaucrat-in-chief, a low-profile executor of daily governance tasks.

THERE WAS DISTINCT DISTRIBUTION OF POWER IN THE SONIA-MANMOHAN *JUGALBANDI*: 10, JANPATH WAS THE POLITICAL POWER CENTRE, DR SINGH THE BUREAUCRAT-IN-CHIEF

In the early years—especially between 2005 and 2008—the dualism actually worked. Riding on the tailwinds of a high-growth trajectory in the final Vajpayee years, the UPA pushed forward purposefully. The left-of-centre imprint on policymaking saw a series of important welfarist measures, from a nationwide right-to-employment guarantee scheme to a wider architecture of rights-driven entitlements, including



The Party Vs Government
May 16, 2005

"...He [Manmohan Singh] is hyper-sensitive to the shifting moods of 10 Janpath. So the disconnect between the PMO and the party works at two levels. First, there is a gap between the PM and the party, which makes him vulnerable to the 10 Janpath brigade, designated as the "interface" between the party and the government. Secondly, there is a disconnect between the PM and his council of ministers, who take their brief from 10 Janpath, not 7 Race Course Road."



Making of the Prime Minister
Aug. 4, 2008

"On July 22, by the final act of exorcism that brought an end to the Red Evil, he [Manmohan] has taken complete copyright of it. Idolised in the drawing rooms of middle India and celebrated in the marketplace (the Sensex went down by 30% in the run-up to the vote but it was up by 8-10% during the debate), he is no longer the prisoner prime minister, at least for a while in public perception. And surprisingly, converts and believers alike refuse to see the moral cost of Singh Shining."



Haunted House
Apr. 4, 2011

"Sushma Swaraj used both logic and poetry to disarm the PM. "*Tu idhar udhar ki na baat kar, yeh bata ki qaafila kyun loota; humein rahzanon se gila nahin, teri rehbari ka sawaal hai* (Don't talk hearsay, tell us why the caravan was looted; we have no grouse against dacoits, but it is a question of your leadership)." In his reply, Manmohan...went on..., "*Maana ki teri deed ke qaabil nahin hoon main; tu mera shauq tou dekh, mera intezaar tou dekh* (I understand that I am not worth your gaze; but have a look at my keenness, have a look at my anticipation for you)."



Trust Deficit
May 27, 2013

"On May 10, Union minister Manish Tewari was sounded out to make public a statement on the PM's behalf on the resignations of Union ministers Pawan Bansal and Ashwani Kumar. The statement, drafted by the PM's adviser T.K.A. Nair, never reached Tewari. It was killed by Congress president Sonia Gandhi's political secretary Ahmed Patel. Over the next few days, rumours of the clash between 7 Race Course Road and 10 Janpath enveloped political Delhi."